

Flatback sea turtle

Shallow-water inhabitant

Length Up to 39 in (100 cm)

Range Tropical Australian waters

Diet Jellyfish, clams, prawns, and seagrass

Restricted to the warm, shallow seas of northern Australia and nearby islands, the flatback seems to prefer muddy river estuaries and coral reefs over the open sea. It has a varied diet, eating almost anything it can catch, and in turn is preyed upon by saltwater crocodiles. Its name refers to the shape of its shell, which is flatter than other sea turtle shells, with upturned edges.

Hawksbill sea turtle

Patterned shell

Length Up to 47 in (120 cm)

Range All tropical oceans

Diet Sponges, jellyfish, clams, and prawns

The hawksbill turtle has a sharp-pointed upper jaw that looks like the beak of a hawk or eagle. It uses it to seize a wide variety of marine animals ranging from crabs to jellyfish, but its favorite prey are sponges growing on tropical coral reefs. It has a strikingly patterned shell, which was once very valuable as the source of the natural material known as tortoiseshell.



Green sea turtle

Undersea grazer

Length Up to 59 in (150 cm)

Range All warm oceans

Diet Seagrass

Unlike other sea turtles, this elegant reptile is a herbivore. It feeds almost entirely on various types of seagrass, which it finds growing in the shallow coastal water of bays, estuaries, and coral reef lagoons. A young green turtle, however, drifts in open water and feeds on small animals. The turtle nests on

sandy beaches throughout the tropics, migrating immense distances to reach them. Its name refers to a layer of green fat beneath its skin, not the color of its shell. As with all sea turtles, it swims by using its long, flattened front flippers like wings to "fly" gracefully through the water at speeds of up to 2 mph (3 kph).



Loggerhead sea turtle

Powerful jaws

Length Up to 84 in (213 cm)

Range Shallow warm oceans worldwide

Diet Shellfish and other marine animals

The loggerhead is an omnivore, which means that it will eat almost anything edible. It has powerful crushing jaws, but like all sea turtles, it has no teeth. It usually feeds in shallow coastal seas, but loggerheads have been tracked crossing the Pacific Ocean to reach their breeding beaches.

Kemp's ridley sea turtle

Under threat



Length Up to 35 in (90 cm)

Range Northwestern Atlantic

Diet Crabs, clams, and jellyfish

One of the smallest sea turtles, Kemp's ridley is also the rarest. Most of the females lay their eggs on a single Mexican beach, and this makes it vulnerable to any catastrophe that might wipe it out altogether. Kemp's ridley is also unusual because it feeds almost entirely on crabs, crushing them in its strong jaws.

